

Chapter 10

The night sky was extremely beautiful.

After sending Ji Jingrong a message, Yin Lingzhu walked to the window and looked up at the sky.

She had no heart to appreciate the stars. The impulsive thought that had suddenly emerged left her uncertain whether it was right or wrong.

A phone rang. She picked up her phone and knew without looking at the screen that it was Ji Jingrong calling.

Only Ji Jingrong would actively contact her.

Yin Lingzhu placed her finger on the screen and pressed the answer button.

"What do you mean by that message? Don't be anxious, explain it to me properly. I'm right at your door."

Ji Jingrong's voice came through the speaker, somewhat distorted, but her urgency was clear.

Yin Lingzhu opened the door and indeed saw Ji Jingrong.

Ji Jingrong had casually thrown on a coat and wore slippers on her feet. She must have rushed out in panic after seeing the message.

Seeing Yin Lingzhu come out, she breathed a sigh of relief. "What happened?"

"Let's talk at my place." Ji Jingrong said to Yin Lingzhu.

Ji Jingrong knew that Yin Lingzhu's room was currently off-limits to her.

Yin Lingzhu nodded and followed Ji Jingrong to her room.

"She said she doesn't like Alphas, so I want to have gland removal surgery¹." Yin Lingzhu held the water cup Ji Jingrong had given her, feeling the glass texture against her palms, which kept her mind very clear.

Hearing her words, Ji Jingrong had many things she wanted to say but couldn't think of what to say.

Privately, Ji Jingrong actually hoped Yin Lingzhu could forget her marriage partner.

These past few months, she had witnessed all of Yin Lingzhu's changes.

Although she didn't know who her marriage partner was, Ji Jingrong felt that no matter who it was, they weren't worth Yin Lingzhu's sacrifice.

"She doesn't like you. No matter what you do, it's useless." Ji Jingrong tried to soften her voice as she persuaded.

Yin Lingzhu couldn't listen to anything right now.

She had looked it up in the afternoon - Si Xin was a Beta.

Yin Lingzhu shook her head. "Will you accompany me?"

The risk of this surgery was extremely high. She was afraid that if she died on the operating table, no one would collect her body.

"You—what's so good about her that's worth you sacrificing so much!" Ji Jingrong also knew the mortality rate of this surgery and couldn't help shouting.

"If she wanted your life, would you give it to her?"

Ji Jingrong gripped Yin Lingzhu's shoulders tightly with both hands. Her hands trembled from the force, trying to make Yin Lingzhu abandon this idea.

The two faced each other.

Yin Lingzhu lowered her head, her voice trembling. "I want to try one last time."

Ji Jingrong released her hands. She saw hope and despair in Yin Lingzhu's eyes.

She stopped trying to persuade her.

Ji Jingrong sat beside Yin Lingzhu and touched her hand. "Alright, I'll go with you. Whenever you want the surgery, I'll accompany you."

Hadn't she had similar thoughts herself?

"But we need to tell the doctor that if you have any discomfort, the surgery must be stopped immediately." Ji Jingrong said.

"Let's go now. Today is my birthday." Yin Lingzhu put down the water cup and spoke with determination.

Yin Lingzhu came to the hospital and requested that You Xiaoxiao be the attending physician.

You Xiaoxiao primarily researched glands, so she could perform this surgery.

But even You Xiaoxiao couldn't guarantee the success rate of gland removal surgery.

After receiving this surgery notice, You Xiaoxiao initially didn't want to take it, but when she saw that it was Yin Lingzhu having gland removal, she couldn't sit still.

Her pheromones were still useful to Yan Si.

You Xiaoxiao hurriedly sent a message to Yan Si, telling her about Yin Lingzhu's surgery.

"Hello, your surgery is too risky. You need to sign a surgical consent form and assume the risks yourself."

You Xiaoxiao looked at Yin Lingzhu and handed her the form that needed signing.

Seeing Yin Lingzhu take the surgical notice, she said to Ji Jingrong, "Hello, what comes next might be somewhat private. Please have the accompanying person step out first."

Yin Lingzhu and Ji Jingrong's eyes met, and she said, "I can handle it alone."

Ji Jingrong patted Yin Lingzhu's shoulder. "If you change your mind, tell me immediately."

After Ji Jingrong left, the room was filled with silence. Yin Lingzhu was the first to break the quiet.

"Did you tell her I was having surgery?" Yin Lingzhu gripped a corner of the form and asked.

You Xiaoxiao held her phone and saw the message Yan Si had sent her. "She knows."

"Moreover, she has a voice message for me to give you."

You Xiaoxiao pressed the play button, and Yan Si's cold voice filled the room.

"You cannot have this surgery." After hearing this, Yin Lingzhu's heart leaped with joy.

She thought Yan Si was still worried about her.

The next words plunged her into an abyss.

"There's one more marking left. After the divorce, even if you die, it has nothing to do with me."

Yan Si's voice message ended there.

Those two short sentences made Yin Lingzhu feel like she had fallen into an ice cellar.

She walked out of the consultation room in a daze.

Despite not having surgery, she looked like all her vital energy had been drained, her face extremely pale.

"What's wrong?" Ji Jingrong asked carefully.

Yin Lingzhu forced herself to rally her spirits and shook her head. "Nothing. Let's go back. I'm not having the surgery."

Although Ji Jingrong was happy she had thought it through, seeing Yin Lingzhu's condition, she didn't dare ask more questions.

Back home, Yin Lingzhu's mind kept replaying Yan Si's words.

If I really died, wouldn't she care either?

Yin Lingzhu felt she should be happy. At least Yan Si didn't want her to die yet. Whatever the reason, Yan Si still cared about her.

Her mind wandered as she came to the balcony and saw clothes hanging on the drying rack.

They were Ji Jingrong's clothes.

She took the clothes down and sat on the sofa, silently folding them, wanting to return them to Ji Jingrong.

After folding them neatly, Yin Lingzhu looked up, and her gaze drifted to the balcony again.

There was a wardrobe placed there, rather oddly.

Yin Lingzhu knew what was in the wardrobe - ten sets of clothes.

Yan Si came once a month. The next morning when Yin Lingzhu woke up, she couldn't see Yan Si, but her clothes were left in the room.

Yin Lingzhu had once asked Yan Si why she didn't wear the clothes.

The answer she got was that the clothes were old and she didn't want to wear them.

Now Yin Lingzhu understood - Yan Si found her dirty².

But Yin Lingzhu hadn't understood then.

Yan Si wouldn't let Yin Lingzhu enter her room, so there was nowhere to put the washed clothes.

Yin Lingzhu simply bought a wardrobe and placed it on the balcony.

Thinking about it now, everything she did was useless.

What good was the wardrobe? Yan Si would never wear those clothes.

Yin Lingzhu laughed self-mockingly, and Ji Jingrong's clothes were forgotten on the sofa.

On the other side, You Xiaoxiao immediately sent a message to Yan Si after Yin Lingzhu left.

She hadn't expected Yan Si's message to contain this.

[Do you know how much harm it causes Yin Lingzhu every time she marks you?]

You Xiaoxiao sent this message.

She didn't know whether it was right or wrong that she had originally brought Yan Si and Yin Lingzhu together.

Yan Si immediately replied.

[How much harm does it cause her? Isn't she an Alpha?]

[Ordinary marking naturally doesn't harm Alphas, but you two aren't ordinary.]

You Xiaoxiao clicked on the screen and sent this text.

Seeing that Yan Si hadn't replied for a long time, You Xiaoxiao typed again.

[You've been relying on suppressants, so once an Alpha marks you, her pheromone loss is very rapid.]

[Yin Lingzhu suddenly differentiated to S-level. How could she withstand so much pheromone loss?]

[Every time she marks you, you feel comfortable, but Yin Lingzhu suffers. Weakness in limbs and fatigue are mild symptoms. If severe, it could damage her glands, and she might never produce pheromones again for the rest of her life.]

You Xiaoxiao explained all the consequences in one breath.

Yan Si's message took a long time to come.

[What does that have to do with me?]

You Xiaoxiao was stunned. She hadn't expected this to be Yan Si's response.

[An Alpha without pheromones - you know what that means, don't you?]

You Xiaoxiao typed these words, not understanding herself why she was sending them to Yan Si.

[Just disabled, that's all]

Yan Si's message once again left You Xiaoxiao stunned.

She felt like she was beginning not to recognize her childhood friend.

You Xiaoxiao shook her head. Probably no one in the world truly knew Yan Si.

She could obtain the position of childhood friend thanks to the You family's long dependence on the Yan family³.

As a child, Yan Si was withdrawn, so the You family ordered You Xiaoxiao to approach Yan Si and keep her company.

Thanks to You Xiaoxiao's thick skin, even when Yan Si resisted, You Xiaoxiao persisted in clinging to her. Therefore, You Xiaoxiao was Yan Si's only friend.

It could be said that she studied glands because of Yan Si.

Whether due to pressure from the You family or her genuine feelings, all her actions had to benefit Yan Si.

You Xiaoxiao recalled her past and opened her computer, the screen displaying Yan Si's physical information.

When Yan Si was well, she was well. When Yan Si was bad, she was bad.

Thinking this, You Xiaoxiao made up her mind.

If Yin Lingzhu's glands were going to be ruined, she would extract the last of her pheromones for Yan Si before they were completely destroyed.

After sending the message, Yan Si placed her phone face-down on the table, her eyes flickering with uncertain light.

Si Xin stood beside her, seeing Yan Si's expression, and stood nervously nearby, not daring to make a sound.

The stars in the night sky continued to twinkle, everyone's thoughts buried in their hearts, unknown to others.

The next morning, Yin Lingzhu discovered her eyes were very swollen.

She hadn't cried before going to sleep last night, but apparently had cried in her dreams.

She smiled, but her eyes were swollen like walnuts, her entire being radiating desolation and distress.

Yin Lingzhu wet a towel and applied it to her eyelids.

Tomorrow was when Yan Si came every month. She couldn't let Yan Si see her like this.

Thinking this, she removed the towel and was about to wet it again when she opened her phone during the gap.

She saw You Xiaoxiao had sent her a message.

[There's a solution for your gland side effects.]

Seeing this message, Yin Lingzhu should have been happy, but now she felt afraid.

Her only asset was her Alpha pheromones.

A question arose in Yin Lingzhu's mind.

If she wasn't an Alpha anymore, would Yan Si still want her?

Yin Lingzhu lightly tapped the screen and replied to the message.

[Okay, I'll come find you tonight.]

She didn't eat anything all day, constantly checking her eyes to see if the swelling had gone down.

Footnotes: ¹ Gland removal surgery (切除腺體的手術) - In Omegaverse, this refers to surgically removing the scent glands that produce pheromones, essentially eliminating one's Alpha/Beta/Omega designation. This is an extremely dangerous procedure with high mortality rates.

² Dirty (髒) - This continues the cruel theme from the previous chapter, where Yan Si considers Yin Lingzhu "dirty" and finds her disgusting.

³ Yan family (晏家) vs You family (尤家) - This reveals the class dynamics, where the You family is subordinate to the powerful Yan family, explaining You Xiaoxiao's complicated loyalty to Yan Si despite witnessing her cruelty.